

Reining in the ROGUE

India's options to deal with its nuclear neighbour are severely limited. Having failed to carry out previous ultimatums, even a military strike is fraught with risk.

| By Raj Chengappa and Saurabh Shukla |

Even as NSG commandos waged a furious battle with terrorists holding Mumbai hostage, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh was addressing the nation on television, hinting that elements from Pakistan were involved in the attack and "there would be a cost if suitable measures are not taken by them". Hours later when Pakistan Prime Minister Syed Yousuf Raza Gilani telephoned Manmohan and offered his nation's sympathy, he was brusquely told that preliminary investigations pointed towards links in Karachi. To this, Gilani offered Pakistan's assistance in investigating these incidents, even adding that the director-general of Pakistan's Inter-Service Intelligence (ISI) agency would visit India. By the next morning, Pakistan's Foreign Ministry, reportedly under pressure from the army, backtracked and said only a director-level official would be visiting. The same day President Asif Ali Zardari in a television interview tried to explain away the U-turn as a "miscommunication", adding the DG could be sent later.

Yet, by then the credibility of the relatively new democratic dispensation in Pakistan had sunk in Indian eyes. It was clear that neither Zardari nor Gilani were "the final word" in Pakistan but Army Chief General Ashfaq Pervaiz Kiyani was. That impression gained further traction when Zardari, in an interview to *Larry King Live*, categorically ruled out handing over terrorists on India's most wanted

PRIME MINISTER
MANMOHAN SINGH
(LEFT); PAKISTAN
PRESIDENT ASIF
ALI ZARDARI



SIPRA DAS

PAKISTAN HAS BEEN ALLOWED TO GET AWAY WITH A 'LOW RISK, HIGH GAIN' POLICY BECAUSE OF ITS NUCLEAR STATUS.